Dyscalculia is dyslexia's much less famous sibling, and it gets far less patience — because being bad at maths is treated as a personality quirk rather than a difference in wiring.

In plain words

Dyscalculia affects the brain's basic sense of number and quantity. It isn't maths anxiety, though that usually follows, and it isn't a gap in teaching. Estimating amounts, remembering sequences of digits, judging time and handling money all stay difficult regardless of effort.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Looking at a number and it meaning nothing — no sense of how big it is.
- Counting on your fingers as an adult and feeling ashamed of it.
- Being unable to estimate how long something will take, at all.
- Reading a phone number, then losing it between reading and dialling.
- Panic at the till while trying to work out the change.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"They're bad at maths."	It's the underlying number sense, not the maths teaching.
"It's just anxiety."	Anxiety is usually the result of years of struggle, not the cause.
"Everyone finds maths hard."	Most people can tell that 40 is roughly double 20 without working it out.
"They'll manage with a calculator."	Calculators help with sums, not with knowing which sum to do.
"It only affects maths lessons."	It affects time, money, directions, cooking, and turning up when you said you would.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Strong verbal and language reasoning.

Creative and intuitive problem-solving.

Excellent at pattern and narrative thinking.

Highly developed workarounds and practical strategies.

Real empathy for anyone told they're just not trying.

What actually helps

- ☐ Write numbers down, don't say them
- ☐ Say clock times, not durations
- ☐ Don't put them on the bill split
- ☐ Allow calculators and apps without comment
- ☐ Break instructions with numbers into steps
- ☐ Give directions as landmarks, not distances

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL	LESS HELPFUL
“I'll text you the number.”	“It's simple, look.”
“Shall I sort the bill?”	“You're an adult!”
“Use whatever helps.”	“Just do it in your head.”

Not carelessness with numbers. A different relationship with quantity altogether.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

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